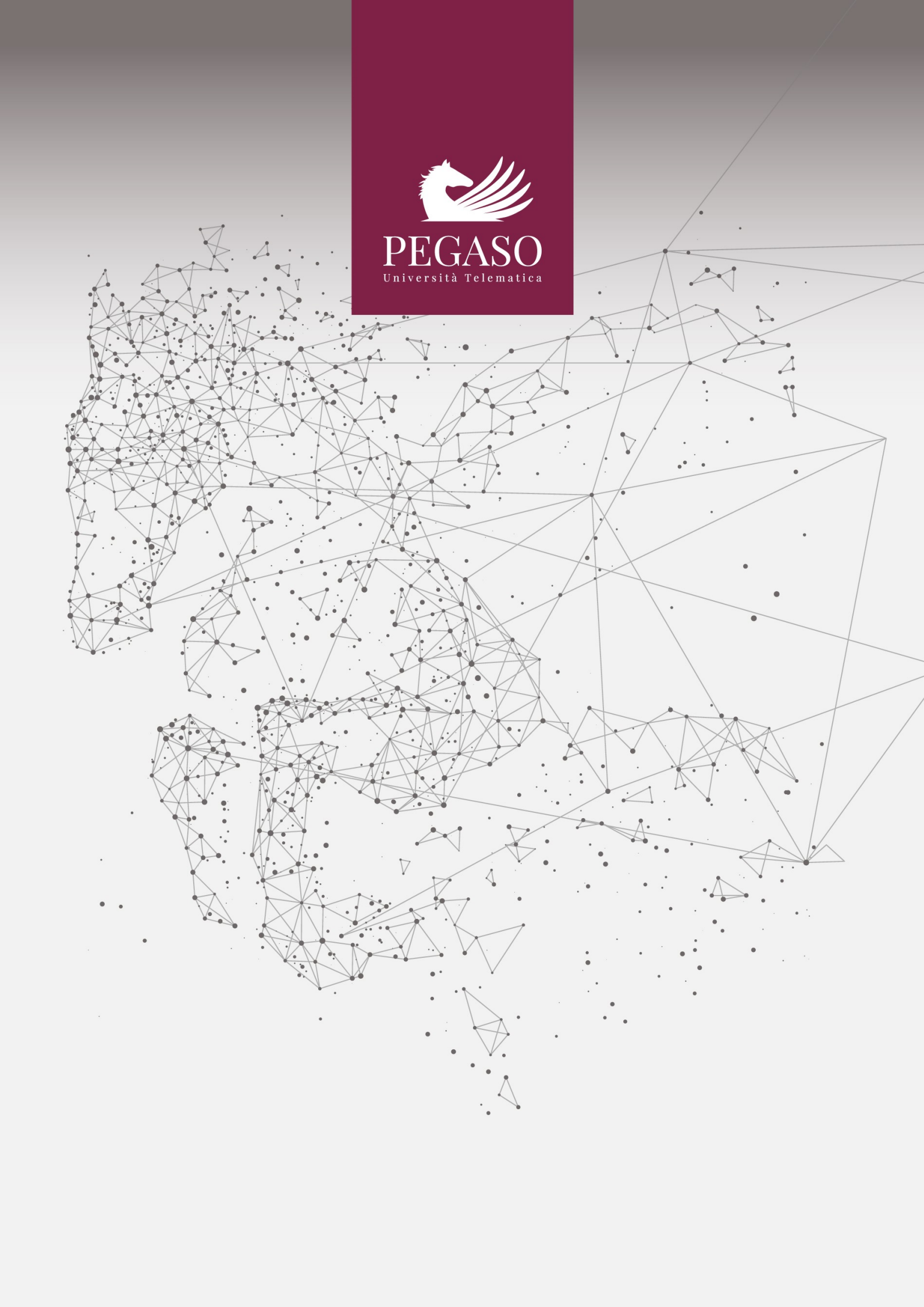

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Indice

1. PRESENT PERFECT SIMPLE 3
2. PRESENT PERFECT SIMPLE VS. PAST SIMPLE 6
3. PRESENT PERFECT CONTINUOUS 7
4. PAST PERFECT SIMPLE AND CONTINUOUS 9
BIBLIOGRAFIA 14

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1. Present Perfect Simple

Present Perfect Simple: have / has + past participle

• We use the present perfect simple:

1 to talk about past experiences when you don't say when something happened, often with ever or never.

2 with just, yet, and already.

3 with superlatives and the first, second, last time, etc.

4 for finished actions (when no time is specified) which have present results.

5 with non-action verbs (= verbs not usually used in the continuous form, e.g. be, need, know, like, etc.) to say that something started in the past and is still true now.

*This use is common with time expressions like How long.?, for or since, all day / evening, etc.

*Don't use the present simple in this situation:

I know Miriam since I was a child.

6 when we say or ask how much / many we have done or how often we have done something up to now.[1]

On Past Participles

Regular past participles end in -ed and are the same as regular past simple forms

(e.g. change → changed, live → lived).

Many past participles are irregular.

Some irregular past participles are the same as the irregular past simple form:

make (infinitive), made (past simple), made (past participle)

Other irregular past participles are different from the irregular past simple form:

write (infinitive), wrote (past simple), written (past participle).

Present perfect with for and since

We use the present perfect with for and since to talk about a situation that started in the past and continues now.

We use for with a period of time.

I've worked here for three years.

[1] C. Latham-Koening, C. Oxenden, K. Chomacki, *English File Upper-Intermediate Fourth Edition*, Oxford, Oxford University Press, 2020 (134)

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We use since with a point in time (when the situation started).

I've known Taylor since 2005.

We never use from with present perfect in this way.

I've lived in Manchester from six months.

I've lived in Manchester for six months.[2]

For + a period (from start to end)

For 20 minutes

For 3 days

For 6 months

For 4 years

For 2 centuries

For a long time

For ever

Since + a point (from then to now)

Since 9am

Since Monday

Since 1997

Since 1500

Since I left school

Since the beginning of time

We use the present perfect simple:

1. to talk about states, single or repeated actions over a long period of time up to the present (often with ever/never, often/always).

- I've always wanted to be an actor.
- Have you ever been to Australia?
- I've only used my mobile phone once since I bought it.
- She's read that book at least ten times.
- That's the first time I've ever eaten octopus.

[2] J. Hughes, H. Stephenson and P. Dummett, *Life Pre-Intermediate Student's Book*, Hampshire, National Geographic Learning, 2019 (168)

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- It's the worst concert I've ever been to.

2. to talk about recent single actions with a present result (often with just, already, yet).

- I've already seen that film and I don't want to see it again.

- Have you finished your essay yet?

- Our friends have just arrived.

* Take Note: In American English, it is acceptable to use the past simple in sentences like these.

For Example: I didn't have breakfast yet. I already saw that film.

3 to talk about an unfinished period of time up to the present (often with for/since, this week/month/year).

- Tomoko has lived in England for five years.

- I've been in love with Stella since 2002.

- I've loved travelling all my life.

- I've disliked bananas since I was a child.

- We haven't had a holiday this year.[3]

[3] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (176)

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2. Present Perfect Simple vs. Past Simple

Present perfect and Past Simple: use

We can use both the present perfect and the past simple to talk about events in the past.

We use the present perfect to talk about events and experiences, when we don't know when something happened, or we don't say because it's not important.

- I've visited over fifty countries.
- He's written some really important books.

We use the present perfect to ask about people's experiences, using ever.

- Have you ever worked abroad?
- Has Jeanne ever seen this film?

We use the present perfect for something that started in the past and continues now.

We use the past simple when we know the exact time something happened:

- I saw Max this morning.
- I visited our Los Angeles office last year.

When we have conversations about experiences in our life, we often start with the present perfect to talk about the experience in general, and then use the past simple to give details.

- Have you ever been skiing?
- Yes, I have. I tried it in California last year.[4]

[4] J. Hughes, H. Stephenson and P. Dummett, *Life Pre-Intermediate Student's Book*, Hampshire, National Geographic Learning, 2019 (168)

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3. Present Perfect Continuous

Present Perfect Continuous: have / has + been + verb + -ing

We use the present perfect continuous:

1 to talk about a recent activity when the effects of that activity can still be seen.

A: Why are you out of breath? B: I've been running.

2 to emphasize how long an action has been going on for, or that it has been repeated many times.

- I've been replying to emails all morning.
- I've been cleaning the house all day.

3 to suggest that an activity is temporary.

- I've been living here for five years but I'm going to move soon.

* Take Note: We don't use verbs that refer to a state (ex. Be, Know, etc) in the continuous form.[5]

We use the present perfect continuous:

1. with action verbs (e.g. run, listen, study, cook) to say that an action started in the past and is still happening now (unfinished actions).

This use is common with time expressions like How long...?, for or since, all day / evening, etc.

* Don't use the present continuous in this situation:

I'm living here for the last three years. (incorrect)

2 for repeated actions, especially with a time expression, e.g. all day, recently.

3 for continuous actions which have just finished (but which have present results).

Present Perfect Simple or Continuous?

To talk about an unfinished action, we normally use the present perfect continuous with action verbs (e.g. run, listen, study, cook) and the present perfect simple with non-action verbs (e.g. be, need, know, like, etc.).

[5] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (176)

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Some verbs can be action or non-action, depending on their meaning, e.g. have piano lessons = action, have a car = non-action.

With the verbs live or work, you can often use the present perfect simple or continuous. However, we normally use the present perfect continuous for more temporary actions.

The present perfect simple emphasizes the completion of an action (= the kitchen has been painted). The present perfect continuous emphasizes the duration of an action (= the painting of the kitchen may not be finished yet).[6]

[6] C. Latham-Koening, C. Oxenden, K. Chomacki, *English File Upper-Intermediate Fourth Edition*, Oxford, Oxford University Press, 2020 (134)

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4. Past Perfect Simple and Continuous

Past Perfect Simple: had + past participle

We use the past perfect simple when we need to make clear that one past action happened before another past action. For the action that happened first, we use the past perfect simple. For the action that happened second, we use the past simple.

- When they got to the station, the train had left.

When we're telling a story, we sometimes also use the past perfect simple to describe events that happened before the start of a story.

- I visited Africa last year. I'd always wanted to go there. So I booked a holiday.

We only use the past perfect simple when we need to make it clear which action happened first. We don't need to use the past perfect simple when:

1. the order of events is the same as the order of the verbs in the sentence.

- He looked down and saw a coin on the ground, so he picked it up.

(not... He had looked down and had seen ...)

2. the order of events is clear.

- They went out on the boat after the storm passed. (not ... the storm had passed)

We often use superlatives in sentences with the past perfect and the past simple.

- It was the biggest fish she'd ever seen.[7]

Past Perfect Continuous: had + been + verb + -ing

We use the past perfect continuous to talk about actions that continued for a period of time before another action or situation in the past. We use it to focus on how long the action lasted. Perhaps the action continued up to the moment we are talking about it, or perhaps not.

- I'd been living in France for three years when we first met.

[7] H. Stephenson, J. Hughes, P. Dummett, *Life Intermediate Student Book Second Edition*, Hampshire, National Geographic Learning, 2019 (160)

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- When I woke up, I saw that it had been hailing.

We often use *already* with the past perfect continuous as well as the past perfect simple to emphasize that the action happened earlier. We also often use *just* to show that the action happened a very short time before.

- She had already been working for two hours by the time we got there.

- We had already been eating for half an hour when our fourth guest arrived.

Exercises

Circle the correct form. In some cases both are possible.

1. She's worked / been working here since July.
2. Your mother has phoned / been phoning three times this morning!
3. The kids are exhausted because they've run / been running around all day.
4. Tim and Lucy haven't seen / been seeing our new house yet.
5. I've never met / been meeting her boyfriend. Have you?
6. It's snowed / been snowing all morning.
7. Bill has just gone / been going to work. He won't be back till this evening.
8. My sister has lived / been living alone since her divorce.
9. I've read / been reading all morning. I've now read / been ready 100 pages.

Complete the sentence with the present perfect simple or continuous of the verb in brackets.

Ex. I've bought a new car. Do you like it? (buy)

10. We……Jack and Ann for years. (know)
11. You look really hot. ……..at the gym? (you / work out)
12. Emily ……her homework yet, so I'm afraid she can't go out. (not do)
13. They don't live in London – they …….(move)
14. I hope they're getting on OK. They ……..a lot recently. (argue)
15. We ……..for hours. Is this the right way? (walk)
16. Why is my laptop switched on?.....it? (you / use)

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17. Oh no! I ……..my finger on this knife. (cut)[8]

Read the situations and write past perfect simple sentences from the words in brackets.

Ex. You went to Sue's house, but she wasn't there. (she / go / out) .. She had gone out.

18. You went back to your home town after many years. It wasn't the same as before. (it / change / a lot)

19. Rachel to the party, but she couldn't come. (she / arrange / to do something else) .....

20. You went to the cinema last night. You got to the cinema late. (the film / already / begin) .....

21. It was nice to see Dan again after such a long time. (I / not / see / him for five years) .....

Read the situations and make past perfect continuous sentences from the words in brackets.

Ex. I was very tired when I arrived home. (I / work / hard all day) I'd been working hard all day...

22. The two boys came into the house. They had a football and they were both very tired. (they / play / football) .....

23. I was disappointed when I had to cancel my holiday. (I /look / forward to it) .....

24. Ann woke up in the middle of the night. She was frightened and didn't know where she was. (she / dream) ...

25. When I got home, Tom was sitting in front of the TV. He had just turned it off. (he / watch / a film)……[9]

[8] C. Latham-Koening, C. Oxenden, K. Chomacki, *English File Upper-Intermediate Fourth Edition*, Oxford, Oxford University Press, 2020 (134)
[9] R. Murphy, *English Grammar in Use Third Edition*, Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 2004 (31, 33)

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Translate the following text into Italian.

26. Morgan has lived in London for 7 years but for the past six months she has been commuting to Oxford three times a week in her new role as marketing director. Before she agreed to this new position, she had been thinking about leaving the company altogether. Morgan has organized three conferences since March of last year and she predicts that there will be two more this year.

Exercise answer key

1.Both are possible.

2. Your mother has phoned.

3. …they've been running around all day.

4. Tim and Lucy haven't seen our new house yet.

5 I've never met her boyfriend.

6. It's been snowing all morning.

7. Bill has just gone to work.

8. Both are possible.

9. I've been reading all morning. I've now read 100 pages.

10. We have known Jack and Ann for years.

11. Have you been working out at the gym?

12. Emily hasn't done her homework yet.

13. They have moved.

14. They have been arguing a lot recently.

15. We have been walking for hours.

16. Have you been using it?

17. I've cut my finger on this knife.

18. It had changed a lot.

19. She had arranged to do something else.

20. The film had already begun.

21. I hadn't seen him for five years.

22. They had been playing football.

23. I had been looking forward to it.

24. She had been dreaming.

25. He had been watching a film.

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26. Morgan vive a Londra da 7 anni, ma è dagli ultimi sei mesi che fa la pendolare a Oxford tre volte alla settimana per il suo nuovo ruolo di direttore marketing. Prima di accettare questa nuova posizione aveva pensato di lasciare del tutto l'azienda. Morgan ha organizzato tre conferenze dal marzo dello scorso anno e prevede che quest'anno ce ne saranno altre due.

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